

Influence of Student-Teacher Relationship on Students' Attitude towards Learning in Secondary Schools in Loima Sub-County, Kenya

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The study investigated on the influence of student-teacher relationship towards learning in Loima Sub –County, Kenya. The study was guided by Cohen's School Climate Theory. Concurrent mixed methods research design was applied in this study. The target population was 10 principals, 142 teachers and 878 students. Purposive, stratified and simple random sampling techniques were used to obtain a sample size of 8 principals, 104 teachers and 264 students. Data was collected by use of questionnaire, interview guide, and observation schedule. Cronbach's Alpha coefficient was used to determine the internal reliability of instruments' results. Quantitative data was analysed using descriptive statistics such as means, frequencies and percentages. Qualitative data was analysed using themes and presented in form of narratives and direct quotations. The hypothesis was tested using Chi-square test of independence. The study findings revealed that student-teacher relationships influenced learners' attitude towards learning.

Keywords: Student-Teacher Relationships; Students' attitude, Cohen's School Climate Theory, Loima Sub-County, Kenya

Introduction

Study Area

The study was carried out in Loima Sub County which is found in the north rift region of Kenya. According to the Kenya Population and Housing Census report (2019), Loima constituency has an area of approximately 8,914.8 sq. km with a population of about 107,795 people. It has the highest illiteracy levels in Kenya with only 1% of the population having secondary level of education, tertiary colleges and university. Apart from being the poorest part of Turkana County (KNBS report, 2013), Loima Sub County has a total of ten boarding secondary schools with a population of about 3,780 students according to the records at the SCDEs office. The area connects Lodwar Town and Uganda. Loima is situated in a rural area. The main economic activity of the people of Loima is pastoralism. The people who live in the urban area of the sub-county own small shops, *posho* mills, butcheries, hotels, pubs, and sell *miraa* from Uganda and West Pokot County. Electricity, piped water and internet connectivity are mostly accessible in the urban parts of Loima only.

Background of the Study

Students' attitude is a psychological tendency that is expressed by evaluating a particular entity with some degree of favour or disfavour (Fisher & Rickard, 2018). It is also a predisposition or a tendency to respond positively or negatively towards a certain idea, object, person, or situation. According to Mensah, Okyere, and Kuranchie (2023), attitude is concerned with an individual's way of thinking, acting and behaving towards the teacher, the immediate social group with which the individual learner relates, and the entire school system. Han and Carpenter (2024) stated that attitude consist of cognitive, affective and behavioural reactions that individuals display towards an object or the surroundings based on their feelings or interest.

Attitude is a hypothetical construct that cannot be observed directly, but can be inferred from measurable reactions to the object (Ajzen, 2023), as it is the case in students' learning in this study. Emotionally supportive teacher-student interactions help students to express their social, sentimental, and even academic needs. Creating effective ways of classroom organisation and management of classroom activities is related to this type of interaction and practice. In school, students should be able to receive appreciation through awards and recognition, and they should be valued for the efforts they make in class or in extracurricular activities (Hafen et al. 2015).

Marzano and Miller (2017) contended that students with a positive attitude towards school were likely to excel in school activities. On the contrary, students with a negative attitude

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cannot trust the school environment, and as a result, effective learning may not be realised. They also argued that experiences form the attitudes of students in their daily school life environment are developed by the interaction of students with different components of the school system, like environment, curriculum, and programme needs. Oblinger (2010) opined that commitment toward learning goes beyond the acquisition of knowledge and skills, but it includes the ability to think critically and solve complex problems, work collaboratively, communicate effectively and pursue self-directed learning or meta-cognition. Attitude towards learning, therefore, focuses more on the behaviour of the students in the whole process of learning.

In Nigeria, the issue of the negative attitude of students has been of much concern to the government, parents, teachers and even students themselves (Ajao, 2021). While several factors can determine the attitude of the learners, bullying is believed to be a possible factor that can bring about a negative attitude toward learning. This was established by Jan and Husain (2019), who contended that “bullying among students not only decreases academic performance but also causes mental health problems and physical injury. If the learning environment is characterised by bullying, learners may feel unfriendly to learning, and they may resort to being truants (Acquah, Lloyd, Davis, & Wilson, 2024). To teachers, a good student is eager to learn and has a positive attitude towards learning. The indicators of such a student include class attendance, completion of assignments, participation in co-curricular activities and level of discipline.

Positive relations between teachers and learners and teacher behaviours can meaningfully influence student engagement (Groves et al., 2015). Such a relationship is acknowledged by empathy, caring, participation, and esteem. According to Frisby (2019), all examples of teacher positive behaviours investigated to date are teacher care, stroke, immediacy, credibility, simplicity, approval, and praise. Through these interactions, students encounter emotional and attitudinal stability and obtain satisfactory emotional support from their teachers which results in effective learning and academic success (Pekrun and Schutz, 2007; Nishioka, 2019).

Statement of the Problem

Schools in Loima Sub-County face numerous challenges, including a lack of adequate classrooms, insufficient teachers, inadequate teaching and learning aids, and poor infrastructure like electric power and network connectivity. This is compounded by a high rate of indiscipline among students, characterised by lateness, absenteeism, rudeness, bullying, fighting, and drug abuse. These issues occur in a sub-county with the highest illiteracy and poverty levels in Kenya. Consistently, schools in this area have failed to achieve a mean grade above D+ in the Kenya Certificate of Secondary Edu-

cation (K.C.S.E).

While a direct link between these environmental factors and students' academic outcomes is plausible, a review of existing literature reveals a research gap. For instance, a study in Narok County by Magati, Waititu, and Ondigi (2024) focused on how different teaching methods influence academic achievement in Physics, indicating that alternative methods led to higher scores. Similarly, Okata (2022) established that the instructional environment significantly impacts academic performance in Nairobi County. However, this study did not specifically examine students' attitudes toward learning. Furthermore, Surum (2018) investigated school climate's effect on academic performance in Dadaab Refugee Camp and found no significant relationship. These studies, while relevant, primarily focus on academic performance and school climate rather than the more nuanced relationship between the school environment and students' attitudes towards learning.

The current study aims to fill this gap by investigating the influence of the school environment on secondary school students' attitudes toward learning in the challenging context of Loima Sub-County, Kenya.

Research Question

The study was guided by the following research question:

How does student-teacher relationship influence students' attitude towards learning in secondary schools in Loima Sub-County, Kenya?

Null Hypothesis

The following hypothesis was tested.

H_{01} : There is no relationship between student-teacher relationships in schools and students' attitude towards learning in Loima Sub-County.

Significance of the Study

The findings of the study will be beneficial to students because once there is a positive relationship with their teachers, they will develop stronger social-emotional skills. In addition, these students are more likely to display an increased amount of academic performance. The results will also allow students to feel confident through exploration and taking risks in their academic tasks. The students are likely to feel comfortable in school when the teachers encourage them in their learning and social interactions. One primary benefit of a healthy student-teacher relationship is that the teachers work to improve their interpersonal and professional skills.

Table 1*Sample Frame*

Group	Population (N)	Sample Size (n)
Schools	10	8
Principals	10	8
Teachers	142	104
Students	878	264
Total	1,040	384

Research Design and Methodology**Research Design**

This study used a concurrent mixed-methods research design. The study targeted all 10 public secondary schools in Loima Sub County. The quantitative design that was employed was cross-sectional, while the qualitative design was phenomenology. The Cross-sectional design enabled the researcher to collect data from the target population at a single point in time. The phenomenology design enabled the researcher to describe the school environment as experienced by the students, teachers and principals.

Sampling

The researcher employed simple random, stratified and purposive sampling methods to get the sample size from the targeted population whose data was collected.

Instruments

Data collection was done using a questionnaire, interview guide, and an observation schedule.

Validity

Research and evaluation experts, consisting of research lecturers, examined the face and content validity of the research instruments with a focus on the appropriateness of the questions and the language used. A panel of five members examined the validity of the items using a benchmark validation rubric instrument for the questionnaires and interview guide developed by the researcher.

Reliability

Cronbach's alpha was used to establish reliability.

Analysis

Descriptive statistics such as percentages and frequencies were used to analyse the quantitative data.

Table 2*Frequency Distribution: Student-Teacher Relationships and Learning Attitudes*

Student-Teacher Relationship	Attitude Towards Learning	Positive	Neutral	Negative	Total
Positive	Count	121	44	43	208
	Expected	115.8	41.8	50.4	208.0
	Count				
	% within Relationship	58.2%	21.2%	20.7%	100.0%
	% within Attitude	82.3%	83.0%	67.2%	78.8%
	% of Total	45.8%	16.7%	16.3%	78.8%
Negative	Count	26	9	21	56
	Expected	31.2	11.2	13.6	56.0
	Count				
	% within Relationship	46.4%	16.1%	37.5%	100.0%
	% within Attitude	17.7%	17.0%	32.8%	21.2%
	% of Total	9.8%	3.4%	8.0%	21.2%
Total	Count	147	53	64	264
	Expected	147.0	53.0	64.0	264.0
	Count				
	% within Relationship	55.7%	20.1%	24.2%	100.0%
	% within Attitude	100.0%	100.0%	100.0%	100.0%
	% of Total	55.7%	20.1%	24.2%	100.0%

Presentation and Discussion of the Findings

Table 2 shows the frequency distribution of student-teacher relationships' influence on students' attitude towards learning.

According to Table 2, 208 (78.79%) of students reported having a positive relationship with their teachers. This shows that majority of teachers showed learners kindness, compassion, patience, confidentiality, respect, care, and they were responsive to their needs. P2 observed that:

The relationship is good. Students are friendly and respectful to their teachers. On the other hand, teachers are working hard to support and mentor them to dream big (14th August, 2024).

Teachers with such virtues and principles demonstrate professionalism that conforms to the spirit of the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child (1989). As pointed out by Akram and Li (2024), there was a need for educators to foster communication, provide personalised support, and cultivate a sense of belonging in education settings in order to positively impact students' attitudes towards learning. On the contrary, 56 (21.21%) of the students reported having negative student-teacher relationships. This, in essence, means that a few of the teachers in Loima Sub-County either do not respect, guide and counsel, show care and compassion, value, show recognition, or even treat all learners fairly and equally. This finding is in line with the opinion of Principal P1, who said that:

The relationship between teachers and students is good. However, there have been one or two cases where learners felt a certain teacher was overdoing the punishment or not interested in their academic wellbeing (7th August, 2024).

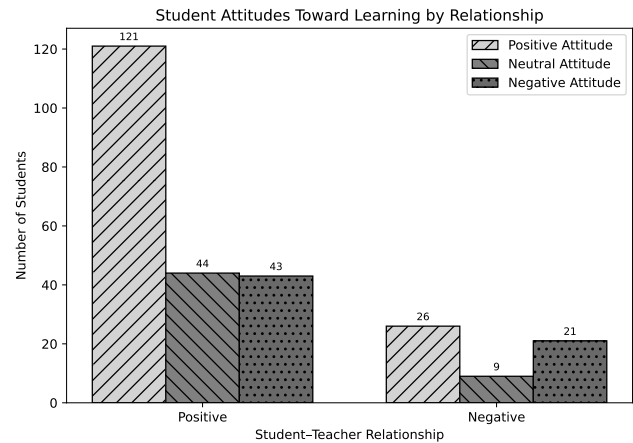
According to Alcantud-Marín et al. (2024), conflict in teacher–student relationships is positively associated with school avoidance and negatively related to school liking, self-regulation, and cooperation in the classroom. Therefore, students experiencing high levels of conflict with teachers are more likely to develop a negative attitude towards learning, leading to absenteeism and exhibiting lower academic engagement tendencies. Thus, educators are encouraged to resolve conflicts with students by the use of restorative practices and avoid exclusionary disciplinary measures, such as suspensions and expulsions, leading to increased instructional time and better student engagement (Learning Policy Institute, 2023).

The data presented in Table 2 shows that the observed and the expected counts when the student-teacher relationships are both positive and negative differ, suggesting that there may be a real relationship or effect happening since the pattern in the data does not perfectly match what would be expected by random chance alone. The information presented in Table 2 was then used to generate a bar graph to compare students' attitude towards learning when the student-teacher relationships were both positive and negative, as shown in Figure 1.

According to the information displayed in Figure 1, 136 (65.38%) of students develop a positive attitude towards learning when the student-teacher relationship is positive, compared to 26 (46.43%) when the student-teacher relationship is negative. Nazish et al. (2024) observed that students' motivation to learn and academic performance were strongly influenced by the quality of teacher–student relationships, characterised by emotional support and approachability. Further, 38 (18.27%) of the students developed a negative attitude towards learning when student-teacher relationship was

Figure 1

Student-Teacher Relationships' Influence on Students' Attitude towards Learning



positive, compared to 21 (37.50%) when student-teacher relationship was negative.

Negative teacher–student relationships can increase anxiety in students and lead to limited motivation in the classroom. Such relationships often thwart children's basic need for relatedness and diminish feelings of belonging at school, thereby obstructing motivational processes that drive academic achievement (Split et al., 2012).

Principal P2, who was interviewed, seemed to concur with this finding. In the opinion of Principal P2,

having a good relationship between the teacher and the learner is a necessary ingredient for the teaching and learning process. Students' attitude towards learning is positively affected by encouraging teachers. Teachers are also pleased by respectful and hardworking students (14th August, 2024).

Test of Hypothesis

The following null hypotheses were tested at the 0.05 level of significance. The hypothesis was tested by the use of Chi-square test of independence. The results are shown in Table 3.

Chi-square was used to test for the relationship between the student-teacher relationships and secondary school students' attitude towards learning in Loima Sub-County. The null hypothesis was: there is no relationship between student-teacher relationships and secondary school students' attitude towards learning in Loima Sub-County. The p-value obtained was 0.033, which is less than the set significance level of 0.05. Thus, the null hypothesis is rejected. Therefore, there is a significant relationship between the student-

Table 3*Chi-Square: Student–Teacher vs. Learning Attitudes*

Test	Value	df	Asymp. Sig. (2-sided)
Pearson	6.81	2	.033
Chi-Square			
Likelihood	6.36	2	.041
Ratio			
Linear-by-Linear	5.12	1	.024
Association			

Note: N=264

Table 4*Cramer's V for the Strength of Association Between Student–Teacher Relationships and Students' Attitudes Toward Learning*

Measure	Value	Approx. Sig.
Cramer's V	.161	.033
N	264	

teacher relationships and secondary school students' attitude towards learning in Loima Sub-County.

The meaning of the finding is that students' attitude towards learning is influenced by the nature of the relationship that exists between students and their teachers. The finding shows that students develop a positive attitude towards learning when their teachers show care, recognise their efforts, reinforce work well done, show affection, compassion, or even reward good behaviour. This can attract students' interests, foster good learning habits, establish a positive learning atmosphere, increase a student's motivation to learn and pre-

dict student engagement (Chen, 2022).

The strength of the association between the student-teacher relationship and students' attitude towards learning was determined using Cramer's V, as shown in Table 4.

The Cramer's V value shown in Table 4 is 0.161. This value indicates the existence of a weak association between student-teacher relationships and secondary school students' attitude towards learning. This implies that a positive student-teacher relationship has a minimal positive influence on students' attitude towards learning, while negative student-teacher relationship also has a minimal negative influence on secondary school students' attitude towards learning in Loima Sub-County.

Conclusion and Recommendations

Conclusion

It was also concluded that majority of teachers in Loima Sub-County were supportive, caring, and compassionate based on the finding that majority of the learners reported having a positive student-teacher relationship.

Recommendations

Based on the conclusion of the study, the following recommendations were made to different stakeholders

The school administrators should organise talks concerning the importance of teachers developing good and healthy relationships with students. Teachers should be reminded from time to time to find the best possible means to maintain a good relationship with students.

Student leaders should frequently remind their fellow students about the importance of establishing good relationships with teachers. This can be done through notices and during assembly gatherings.

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